"Stand Back" said the Elephant, "I'm Going to Sneeze!"

By Patricia Thomas

"Stand back," said the elephant,
"I'm going to sneeze!
I hate to alarm you,
But I don't wish to harm you.
My friends, I fear
It's clear . . .
Oh, dear,
You'd better stand back, I'm going to sneeze."

INTRODUCTION

All the animals are in a panic. The elephant's sneeze would blow the monkeys out of the trees, the feathers off the birds, the stripes off the zebra. Even the fish and the fly, the crocodile and the kangaroo, know what a catastrophe that sneeze would be. "Please don't sneeze!" they beg. . . . Knowing the havoc it will cause, all the animals try to prevent the elephant from sneezing. "Stand back," said the elephant, "I'm going to sneeze!" By Patricia Thomas

"Oh no, oh no!"

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Cried the buffalo.

"You're so big and strong

And your trunk is so long,

Your sneezes send everyone flying along,

Bumping and thumping down a pathway and trail,

Bouncing and jouncing head over tail,

Tumbling and bumbling . . .

Your sneeze is a gale . . . .

Or a hurricane!

I hate to complain.

But please,

Don't sneeze!"

"No, no, please,

Don't sneeze,"

Cried the monkeys in the trees.

"You make such a breeze

When you sneeze.

The last time you blue us right out of the trees.

The branches began to bend and to sway

And some of us landed so far way

We didn't get back until the next day.

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The leaves all went whirling
And tumbling and swirling,
And the flowers
Shook for hours
The last time you sneezed.
Even a cough
Would knock some of us off.
Oh, please,
Don't sneeze!"

With a shriek
The parrot opened his beak.
"The elephant says he's going to sneeze!"
"Oh, Elephant, please!" cried the birds in the trees.
"The last time you sneezed we lost every feather.
We didn't know whether
We'd ever get back together.
Every parakeet
Was bare as a sheet
From his head to his feet.
What's more, all the whales
Had peacock's tails,

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And the wings of the cockatoo
Were stuck on the kangaroo.
You must confess
It was quite a mess,,
Very confusing
And not too amusing.
Even a snuffle
Makes our feather ruffle.
Oh, please,
Don't sneeze!"

"Fly, fly," called the birds to the bees.
"The elephant says he's going to sneeze."

"Oh, no," buzzed the bees.
"Not a sneeze! Not a sneeze!
The last time he blew off our stings
And our wings
And we had to make do
With rose thorns and glue.
Furthermore . . . what a shock
We all had to walk . . .

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On our knees,
If you please,
(And that's hard on bee's knees)
While our wings grew back in.
What a sin!
Oh, please,
Don't sneeze!"'

"Beware, beware,"
Called the bees to the bear.
"The elephant says he's going to sneeze."

"Oh, please,
Not a sneeze,"
Said the bear,
"That's not fair.
I declare,
The last time he sneezed he blew off all my hair,
And left me so bare
I spent the whole winter in long underwear –
Nothings so sad as a bear that is bare.
The poor giraffe

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(Don't laugh)
Almost bent in half,
And the alligator's snout
Was turned inside out
The last time he sneezed.
A sniff or a snuff
Is bad enough . . .
But a sneeze!
Oh, please,
Don't sneeze!"

I' don't suppose
You could hold your nose,
Or wait awhile?"
Asked the crocodile
With a sad little smile.

"Oh my,
Do try,"
Said the fly.

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"We wish,"
Said the fish,
"You would
If you could.
The last time you blew off all the scales
From our heads to our tails,
And our gills
Got the chills
Our skin
Is so thin.
If you do it again
We'll freeze!
Oh, please,
Don 't sneeze!"

Then zebra yelled, "Yipes,
You'll blow off my stripes,
Plus lots and lots
Of the leopard's spots,
And all of the snakes will be tied up in knots!"

The hippopotamus

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Said, "A lot of us
Will fall right on our bottom-us
If you sneeze.
So please,
Don't sneeze."

"I'm sorry, my friends," said the elephant sadly,
"About all of this I do feel badly.
If I could keep from sneezing I'd do it gladly.
But I have such a twitch
In my trunk, and an itch,
Plus a bit of a tickle,
And even a prickle.
You must run fly, and hop.
I'm afraid I can't stop.
I would
If I could,
But there's nothing to do . . . .
Ah . . .
Ah . . . "

"BOO!"

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Shouted a little gray mouse
Jumping out of his house.
He stood right up on his little tiptoes,
Stuck out his tongue, and wiggled his nose.

"Eek!" shouted the elephant, jumping up in the air,
"That's a mouse! That's a mouse standing there!
I must hid in a tree
Before he gets me
Or jump in the lake
For goodness sake!
Don't scare me!
Please spare me!"

The mouse laughed, "Oh, pooh!
Now what could id do?
A little thing like me to a big thing like you?
I only wanted to give you a scare,
And it worked as sure as you're standing there.
Elephant, think about it, please!
You completely forgot to sneeze!"

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"Well, what do you know?"
Laughed the elephant. "That's so!
It's astounding,
Confounding.
As I live and breathe!
I don't think I really have to sneeze."
He began to giggle, "He, he, he, he!
That's the funniest thing that has happened to me!
Ha, ha, ha! Ho, ho, ho!"
The elephant shook from his head to his toe.
He ho-hoed, and ha-haed.
He giggled and guffawed.
He chortled and chuckled
Until his knees buckled.

He sat down and rolled from side to side.
In fact, the elephant laughed till he cried.
He laughed till the ground was shivering and shaking
And all of the trees were quivering and quaking.
The monkeys came tumbling out of the threes,
And the strings fell off every one of the bees.
The bird's feathers went flying

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To goodness-knows-where,

All of the hair

Fell off of the bear.

The giraffe

Bent in half,

And the alligator's snout

Turned inside out.

The fish lost their scales

From their heads to their tails.

The zebra yelled, "Yipes!

There go my stripes!"

While the hippo went thump

Right on his plump . . . . you-know what!

And into a puddle

The mouse went . . . ker-plop!

Then he sat up and shouted,

"This simply must stop!

We're terribly glad you don't have to sneeze

But if you must laugh, laugh softly.

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Oh, Elephant, please!"

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AWARD HISTORY

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